

information by itself is as harmless and useless as a random assortment of ones and zeroes; what matters is how that data is used. What's even more interesting is how accustomed we've grown to the rewards that Big Data offers us, and this despite us raising a hue and cry over the supposed loss in privacy that this data gathering entails.

The NSA gathering data on the world sent everyone into a tizzy, but Google and Facebook gathering data on you is something we didn't even notice (or hoped to ignore) until very recently. The difference between the NSA's and Google's or Facebook's approach is that the NSA has total control over that information, information that can be used to create trouble for you as an individual or even your community at large. The fear is that this information is probably being misused by the (U.S.) government and we're worried that that information could be used to hang a sword over our heads.

Google, Facebook, Zomato and other such companies are gathering such data, but they're also promising you complete privacy, a service that you'll gladly avail and results that you're very happy with. It's a question of respecting privacy and offering a valuable service than of ripping you off.

Would you rather give up the comfort of Google Now's traffic updates if you're a regular driver, Last.fm's music recommendations, Zomato's restaurant recommendations and so much more? You won't, because it's convenient, you don't believe you're divulging too much and you're more than satisfied with the service being provided. Why wouldn't you want Netflix to suggest the perfect movie for a Saturday night?

Government institutions like the NSA are what're giving Big Data its bad name. Both exploit the Big Data they gather to satisfy their personal agendas (we fear). To such companies and institutions you're nothing more than a pot of gold or a psychological profile. You're probably much more valuable than even that to Google or Facebook, but such companies need you to trust them if they're to make money and that trust is earned by treating you with respect and respecting your boundaries. Once any of these companies overstep that line, their entire world will come crumbling all around



Wonobo.com in action. Big Data meets Street View.

them. Unless they generate enough data to attain omniscience of course, which is a different matter entirely.

The tenacious fingers that feed Big Data's insatiable appetite are everywhere, slowly but inexorably dipping into every pie and extracting information. There is no escaping it and it's high time we embraced it and found ways to deal with it rather than fear it. If it gives you any consolation, it's most likely that you've already added a surprising amount of

information to the Big Data pool somewhere or the other already.

Keystones

There are two keystones that the above endeavours depend on – both self-supporting – and those are Big Data and localisation. Big Data because your business will be nothing without it, and localisation because it's the little niches where you're making the most money, hundreds and thousands of little niches. Targeted advertising is just one example of a service that's making money off niches (where do you think Facebook got the \$19 billion for WhatsApp?).

Big Data is a concept that's entirely based on localisation. The whole point is to give you (or the controller of that data) the information to respond to any scenario with the most appropriate response.

The Earth is a world of individuals, people with needs and desires that are unique to themselves. Big Data can give someone the power to fulfil that need, exploit that desire and even hold that individual hostage. Accomplishing any of the aforementioned tasks is not easy, but it is possible.

As someone who intends to make Big Data work for them, you're responsible for the people you serve. Treat the data with respect, treat the individual with respect, offer your audience a service that offers something of value in exchange for that data and you will have a money-spinning idea of unparalleled efficiency (Steam anyone?).

SURGE PRICING

Uber was recently in the news for its controversial "surge pricing" policy. If you don't know, Uber is a service that offers luxury cab service to anyone who's willing to pay, but at a cost that's determined by demand. A small example of Big Data at work, but on a much smaller scale.

The reason Uber was in the news was because they charged shockingly exorbitant rates to users in New York during a recent snowstorm. While some might call this arm-twisting, Uber simply called it sound decision making. Whether Uber was high-handed or not is for the people to decide, but the fact that the service is still growing is saying something isn't it?

Is this what a Big Data dystopia will be like? Should we allow that to happen? Are we even in a position to prevent this from happening? Who knows, maybe Big Data can help us out here as well!